



PICS: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

UP and Punjab unveil ambitious grassroots sports blueprints

U.P. Sports Secretary and two-time Paralympic medallist Suhas Yathiraj (right) said the State's priority is to "take children away from screens and back to the playing fields."

Under a new policy, a mini-stadium will be built in each of the State's 826 development blocks, with standardised facilities for volleyball, tennis, and wrestling.

"Talent identification and providing quality infrastructure at the grassroots remain our biggest challenges," said Yathiraj. "To address them, the government has expanded the Eklavya Krida Kosh, offering up to ₹5 lakh in cover for athletes, and launched sports schools that combine academics with professional training. Three schools are operational, with three more planned next year."

Yathiraj also pointed to signs of progress: "At the last Asian Games in Hangzhou, nearly 25% of India's medallists were from Uttar Pradesh. Sports reforms do not happen overnight — they come through structured effort."

Harpreet Singh Sudan (left), IAS, Director of Sports, said Punjab's approach to reviving its sporting dominance is built on three pillars — active lifestyle, youth development, and restoring past glory.

Sudan admitted the State's struggles with drug abuse but rejected the idea that the problem is unique. "We acknowledge the issue, but sports is the key we identified to address it," he said.

At the grassroots, the Kheda Vatan Punjab Diyan, featuring 37 disciplines including para sports, has become the State's flagship mass participation programme. Numbers

have surged from 1.5 lakh participants in 2022-23 to 5 lakh in 2024-25, backed by a ₹97.3-crore allocation over three years and cash awards to foster community engagement and talent spotting.

Punjab's 2023 Sports Policy introduced financial and structural reforms, including expanded athlete assistance from ₹10,000 to ₹3 crore and, for the first time, "preparation money" even at the qualification stage of international events. "We have also created a new cadre for outstanding sportspersons, recruiting our past champions into regular government jobs as coaches and administrators. Already, 50 former athletes have joined as junior and senior coaches. Our goal is to employ over 1,700 coaches across various levels," said Sudan.

In terms of infrastructure, Punjab has adopted a pyramidal model: village playgrounds feeding into nurseries, hostels, district facilities, and centres of excellence.

Both States, though following different paths, are betting heavily on grassroots systems, structured support, and cultural revival to build a sustainable sporting future.